

Policy Brief

Gender Dynamics in Climate Resilience

2025

Mambwe District, Eastern Province, Zambia
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The Community Recovery & Resilience Facility (CRRF) Project

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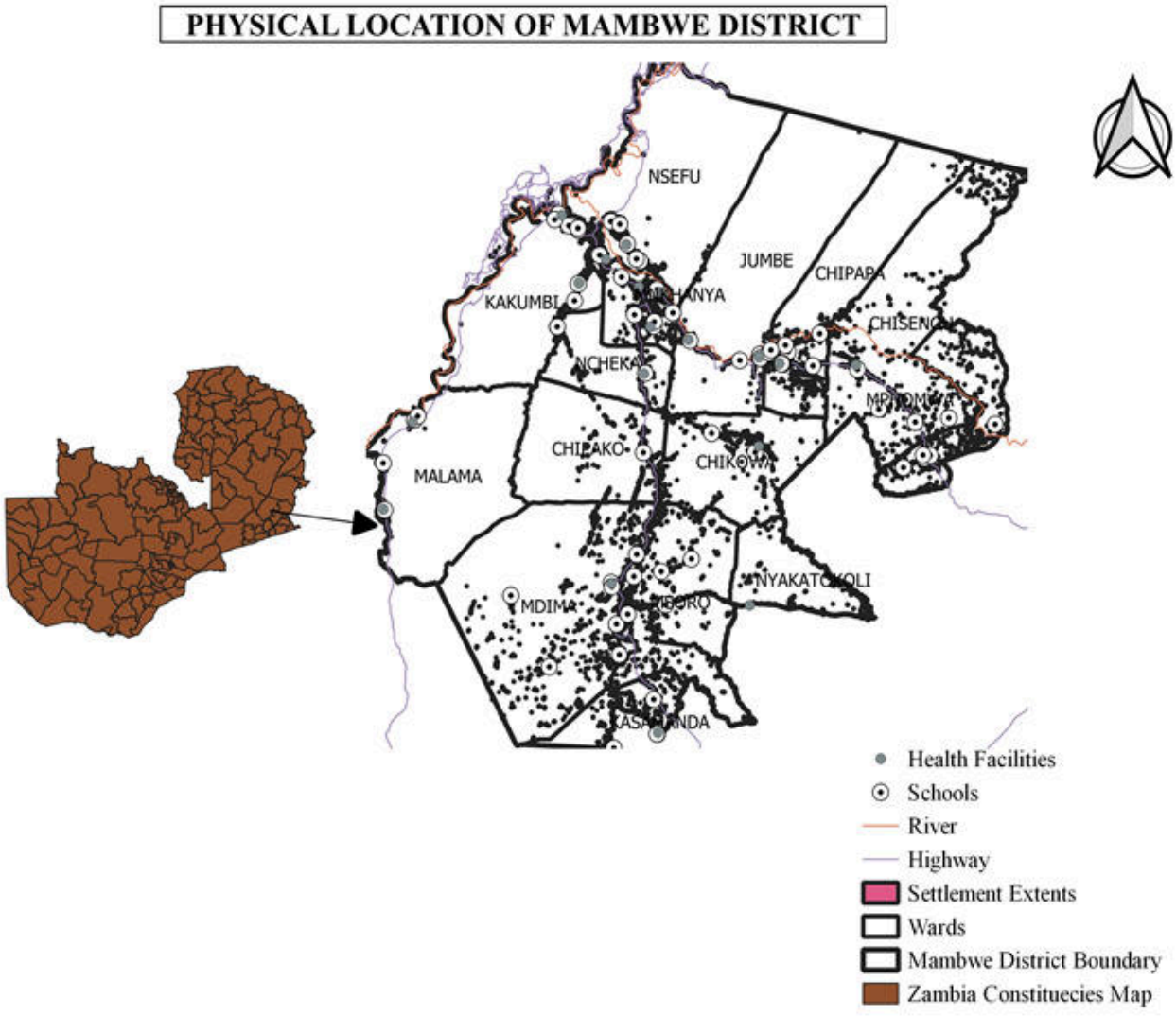
By the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), in collaboration with the Government of Zambia. Alick Nkhata Road, P.O. BOX 31966, Lusaka, Zambia.

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Issue Overview

Mambwe District in Zambia faces recurring climate shocks—including floods, droughts, and pest outbreaks—that disproportionately affect women and other vulnerable groups. Nationally, over 60% of rural women rely on rain-fed agriculture, making them highly susceptible to climate variability. In Mambwe, female-headed households are 15% more likely to experience food insecurity during drought years, and women represent less than 20% of decision-makers in local disaster response committees referred to as Satellite Disaster Management Committees (SDMCs). These disparities are compounded for people with disabilities (PWDs), who face systemic barriers to accessing early warning systems, relief and reconstruction services, and livelihood recovery programs. Global evidence confirms that disasters are not gender neutral: women and girls are 14 times more likely to die during climate disasters than men, according to UNDP estimates.



Map by DMMU

To address these inequities, the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), in partnership with the Government of Zambia, with funding from the Governments of Denmark, Luxemburg and South Korea commissioned a detailed gender analysis for the Community Recovery & Resilience Facility (CRRF) Project. The CRRF is a UNDP-funded initiative implemented by Zambia's Disaster Management and Mitigation Unit (DMMU) to strengthen climate resilience in communities affected by El Niño–Southern Oscillation (ENSO) events. It focuses on rebuilding resilient infrastructure, restoring livelihoods, and promoting gender-responsive recovery, especially for women and people with disabilities. Grounded in inclusive development, the CRRF integrates evidence-based strategies to address the disproportionate impacts of climate shocks on vulnerable populations.

The gender analysis revealed that 72% of women in Mambwe lack access to formal credit, and only 18% participate in climate-resilient agricultural training. The study also highlighted that PWDs—especially women—are often excluded from community planning processes, despite comprising an estimated 10% of the district's population. These findings underscore the need for targeted, inclusive strategies that recognize the intersection of gender, disability, and climate vulnerability.

The first phase of the programme serves as a foundational recovery platform, with current interventions acting as pilot initiatives. These pilots are intended to generate insights and best practices that will shape and scale future phases of the programme.



Picture by UNDP Zambia

Key Findings

1. Gendered Roles & Responsibilities

Women dominate care work and subsistence farming which affects their participation in gainful economic activities, hence locked in the vicious cycle of poverty. Based on the Gender Status Report (2017 -2019), women spend three times more time on unpaid domestic and care work than men. This is collaborated by the world Bank (2022) which estimates women to spend 60% of their time on care roles in southern Africa.

Men control market-oriented agriculture and livestock which advantages them in access collateral for resources required for production.



Picture by UNDP Zambia



Picture by UNDP Zambia

Climate shocks led to a marked increase in women's unpaid labour, with over 68% of women reporting longer hours spent on water collection, caregiving and subsistence farming during crisis periods. Analysis also found that women spend an average of 5.6 hours daily on unpaid domestic tasks, compared to just 1.8 hours for men, exacerbating time poverty and limiting their participation in income-generating activities.

Burdens intensify during climate emergencies, where female-headed households are 22% more likely to experience livelihood disruptions due to compounded responsibilities and limited access to adaptive resources.

2. Access to Resources



Picture by UNDP Zambia

Patriarchal inheritance systems significantly limit women's access to land, with only **14% of women** reporting ownership or control over agricultural plots, compared to **62% of men**.

Women accounted for 48% of beneficiaries under the Farmer Input Support Programme (FISP), indicating moderate strides toward gender parity. However, overall access to agricultural inputs remains limited. The number of farmers supported through FISP falls significantly short of actual demand, leaving many smallholders —especially women and youth—without the resources needed to improve productivity and resilience.

Financial access is limited despite programs like FISP and CDF which are not enough compared to the demand.
Insurance and credit uptake remain low among women as women are risk averse.

3. Decision-Making & Representation

Only 37% of women reported having joint or sole decision-making power over household income and expenditures. In contrast, 61% of men reported being primary decision-makers in their households.

Women held less than 20% of leadership positions in local cooperatives, ward development committees, and Satellite Disaster Committees.

Market access and benefit sharing favour men. Gender-based violence (GBV) and PSEAH risks rise during climate crises and postproduction period in the marketing phase as women fail to play in the market.



Picture by UNDP Zambia

4. Institutional Gaps

Existing policies (SCT, CDF, Women Empowerment) lack full implementation. Community-led structures like SDMC show promise but need scaling. Lack of Gender data for decision making generation Gender capacitation for implementing partners across the different thematic areas





Picture by UNDP Zambia

Policy Recommendations

Strengthen Gender-Inclusive Governance

- Mandate women's representation in Ward Development Committees, satellite disaster management committees and cooperatives.
- Support leadership training for women and youth in natural resources management committees such as water infrastructure.
- Support women's environmental stewardship and participation in climate resilient agriculture.

Expand Access to Productive Resources

- Reform land tenure systems to ensure women's ownership rights.
- Increase women's access to CDF grants and microfinance.
- Encourage women's collective (Pulling) mobilisation of resources through saving groups from the earning in gainful activities for more leverage.

Invest in Gender-Sensitive Infrastructure

- Prioritize water systems and early warning technologies that reduce women's burden.
- Scale up "Cash for Work" and wetlands programs with gender targets.
- Financial access points such as mobile money kiosks to support women entrepreneurs.

Address GBV & SEAH Risks in Climate Response

- Integrate GBV & SEAH prevention into disaster preparedness plans and response activities.
- Train local leaders and responders on gender-sensitive protocols.
- Strengthen the existing Grievance redress system in the community to make it more robust.

Address low literacy levels

- Link women to Adult Learning and Education programs under the Community Development Department with flexible schedules and community-based delivery.
- Link literacy to livelihoods by integrating financial literacy, agricultural extension, and entrepreneurship modules.

Strategic Entry Points

- Leverage traditional leaders to shift norms around land and leadership.
- Use village savings groups and cooperatives to build women's economic agency. And voice
- Partner with NGOs and tourism actors for inclusive livelihood support.
- Build women's agency for stewardship of natural resources

Conclusion

Gender inequality undermines climate resilience. CRRF must embed gender-transformative approaches across all interventions to ensure equitable recovery and sustainable development rooted in resilience in Mambwe District.



Picture by UNDP Zambia

United Nations Development Programme

United Nations House, Alick Nkhata Rd Longacres, Lusaka
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